

Fava bean and artichoke salad with mint and feta cheese

It takes many favas to make a hill of beans. That's no joke. Three pounds [1.5kg] in the pod may easily yield less than a pound [500g] of edible beans. But because they are so large, favas are fun to shuck, and because of their subtle flavor, **delicious** to eat. This is a very attractive, enticing salad, definitely worth the preparation. Because the fava bean season is so short—spring and summer—at other times of the year, I suggest you substitute a pound [500g] of frozen baby lima beans.

Canned artichoke hearts are used here because they save so much work, but if you are so inclined, cook 3 fresh artichoke bottoms until just tender and slice them or cut them into eighths.

3 pounds fresh fava beans, shelled [1.5kg]

1 can (16 ounces) artichoke hearts, drained and quartered [500g]

1 ounce sun-dried tomatoes, softened in hot water if dry, cut into strips [30g]

2 tablespoons shredded fresh mint

2 medium shallots, thinly sliced

2 garlic cloves, minced

⅓ cup extra virgin olive oil [75ml]

3 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

½ teaspoon salt

¼ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

2 ounces feta cheese, crumbled (about ½ cup) [60g]

1. **Fill** a bowl with ice water and set aside. In a large saucepan of boiling salted water, cook the beans for 2 to 3 minutes, depending upon their size. Fava beans soften very quickly, so do not overcook. Drain and immediately plunge the beans into the ice water. Drain again, then peel the outer opaque skin off to reveal the bright green bean inside. Do this by pinching off a small piece of the skin at an edge and then squeezing gently to pop the naked bean out.

2. In a mixing bowl, **combine** the beans with the artichokes, sun-dried tomatoes, 1 tablespoon of the mint, the shallots, and the garlic. Toss gently.
3. **Drizzle** on the olive oil and lemon juice. Season with the salt and pepper. Toss again to coat. Transfer to a serving dish and sprinkle the feta cheese and remaining mint on top. Serve at room temperature.

SERVES 4 TO 6

